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But juxtaposing data from Rwanda and from Ijwi in this fashion produces a paradox: the Ishaza on Ijwi explicitly and universally deny Singa status, and people from all clans on Ijwi distinguish sharply between Mbiriri and Ishaza.¹⁴ Furthermore, the Ishaza have a joking relationship with the Mbiriri which differentiates them and maintains the differences between them.¹⁵ Moreover, on Ijwi 'Jeni' does not appear in the historical affiliations of the Mbiriri.

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The most plausible argument to explain this series of traditions is that Jeni, the putative ancestor of the Ishaza, was a member of a localized group which only later became absorbed within the more all-inclusive Singa identity to conform to Rwandan categories of social identity. This apparently occurred after the Ishaza and Mbiriri emigrations from Rwanda in the late eighteenth century, and thus corresponds with the period when Rwandan cultural norms spread through the area: it is primarily in the Rwandan traditions associated with the central court milieu that the descendants of Jeni are considered as 'Singa.'

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The apparent contradictions in these data then raise the questions of why, despite these apparent indications of common origins, the Mbiriri and Ishaza on Ijwi claim different status from each other and why neither calls itself 'Singa.' This discrepancy between the Ijwi data, which are clear and consistent, and the Rwandan claims can be explained by looking at the assertions of Rwandan associations as separate elements within an evolving process of clan identity formation. While the Mbiriri on Ijwi identify

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specifically as Singa in Rwanda, the Ishaza deny they are Singa; but they, in turn, admit to being descendants of Jeni, a figure apparently since absorbed into the Singa clan category in Rwandan conceptions. From an historical perspective, therefore, the present differences between the Mbiriri and Ishaza traditions on Ijwi attest to localized identities of an earlier period in the area directly east of Lake Kivu—what is today ‘western Rwanda.’ Consequently, in the diagram above the vertical ties represent the primary linkages in historical terms, while the tie between Jeni and the Singa in Rwanda (a tie-in paralleling but contradicting the Ishaza-Mbiriri inter-relation on Ijwi) can be seen as a later phenomenon. Thus the separate identities of these two clans on Ijwi apparently preserve the earlier differentiation of the two groups east of the lake, while the Rwandan situation represents their more recent amalgamation as Singa.

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In this case the effect of the joking relationship between the Mbiriri and Ishaza on Ijwi has been to resist any accommodation of the two groups on Ijwi such as that which occurred in Rwanda and by which Jeni's group has been associated with the Singa. By identifying the Mbiriri as ‘different’ from the Ishaza, this relationship between the two clans on Ijwi serves to maintain social distinctions which may well have existed east of the lake in the late nineteenth century and before. It is also significant that in Rwanda the link noted between Jeni and Singa derives from a source external to the clans in question: it appears only in the Nyiginya traditions of the royal court. It is therefore not internal data, deriving from the participants directly involved, but a statement of royal perceptions. We are dependent exclusively on the Nyiginya court interpretations for these social classifications, and these interpretations most likely refer to a time only after court influence had penetrated the area and after the diffusion of the central court classifications into western Rwanda.

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Though no evidence on this point is presently available from Bwishaza itself, data from neighboring Kinyaga provide some confirmation that the diffusion of the Singa 396 identity within this area is a more recent phenomenon—that the area was earlier characterized by smaller localized group identities. Located in the extreme southwest of present Rwanda, Kinyaga is an area where Rwandan central court political norms and perceptions penetrated only relatively recently; before the mid- or late-nineteenth century, Rwandan penetration affected only a tiny proportion of the population, mostly immigrants who had come from outside Kinyaga during the previous two generations (M. C. Newbury 1975: Chapter II). Perhaps as a consequence of this recent political penetration and the social transformations that went with it, the pattern of social identities in Kinyaga today differs from that in other areas of Rwanda. Whereas in central Rwanda there are essentially two levels of classificatory identities (*ubwoko* and *umuryango*, or ‘clan’ and ‘lineage’), for certain groups in Kinyaga there are three such levels, rather than two. It is interesting that both Mbiriri and Ishaza identities are represented (as intermediary identities) in Kinyaga and both are considered to be sub-groups of the Singa clan. This too reflects the conjunction of these two identities within a larger Singa classificatory identity remarked on above.

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¹⁴ Ijwi interviews: Bahoye 10/2/72; Bakaza 12/2/72; Kavura Kabambare 27/3/72; Mbaraga 28/3/72; Kizinduka 28/3/72; Mukatare 19/4/72.

¹⁵ de Heusch (1966:51–66 and *passim*) argues that such a tie can either reaffirm a former common status or represent an independent origin for clans in the process of coalescing. In this case the evidence is strongly in favor of the latter.

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